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From the editor-in-chief

Two days before India celebrated its 60th Republic Day, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh underwent a major heart surgery for the second time in his life. The decision was taken overnight and the urgency came as something of a surprise to India, leaving the country unsure about the health of its chief executive.

It took 12 hours before we were given any news about the outcome of the prime minister's operation, which fortunately went well. The event though has given rise to many questions and left others unanswered. We are being reassured that Dr Singh will be more active than before and are now being told that full recovery could take between four and six weeks.

There is the greatest empathy for Dr Singh's health but we also know that four to six weeks is a long time in the life of a nation. And this happens to be a particularly delicate time for India, with an election less than three months away, instability in the economy and a deteriorating dialogue with Pakistan.

Even as Dr Singh was hospitalised, what the country—and the Government—needed was for someone to be seen taking charge in his place. Here, the Congress which heads the UPA Government fell short, yet again. The news of Manmohan's surgery was accompanied with the UPA announcing that it had split his duties between various heads: External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee would handle the functioning of the Government and the Finance Ministry, while Defence Minister A.K. Antony stepped in to do Manmohan's ceremonial duties at the Republic Day parade.

In effect there was no single, alternative authority figure, a functional head who could signal a continuity in governance. India was instead given a compromise formula and presented with a leadership vacuum. Thanks to the failure of the Congress to act decisively, what India has at the moment is a headless government.

If Dr Singh's health is under scrutiny so is the health of the Congress party. The unwillingness by the Congress to name any one person to head the Government reflects a fundamental weakness of the party which is still trapped in dynastic tradition. This paralysis has given rise to speculation about the leadership options available to India after the next election.

Our cover story this week is both political and personal. Editor Prabhu Chawla, who has written about 11 prime ministers over the last three decades, along with our political bureau looks at the implications and impact of the Manmohan surgery on the party, on the Government and on the future course of national politics.

Unlike other 70-somethings recovering from heart surgery, Manmohan Singh will have to do twice the work: regain his strength and also find the energy to lead the Congress into the next election campaign as its prime ministerial candidate. If the events of the last 12 months have taken their toll on the prime minister's health, then he must know that the next few months will be even tougher. We wish him well.



OUR OCTOBER
2000 COVER

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(Aroon Purie)